

BALANCER · v2

CATEGORICAL BALANCE · CASE STUDY 18 JUN 2026

P701 · PROPOSAL

The case for change — the current balancer aims for equal **overall** totals per team and stops there. With 9-attribute cards available, it can do much more. Below: the actual 18 Jun teams, the imbalance that crept in, and what a categorical balancer would have done differently.

► What the balancer did on 18 Jun

36 confirmed players · 4 teams of 9 · overall ratings balanced to within 3 points. Looks even. But:

TEAM	OVR	SHO	PAS	DRI	DEF	PHY
Aaron Franklin FC	64	62	65	64	67	69
Gary Edwards FC	63	53	64	61	68	69
Josh Edwards FC	67	65	70	69	62	63
Mikel Winter FC	66	58	68	65	68	72
Spread	±4	±12 ▲	±6	±8	±6	±9

The hidden problems:

- **Gary Edwards FC had 53 shooting** — 12 below Josh Edwards FC. They scored 2 goals in 3 games — they didn't have a finisher.
- **Josh Edwards FC had every dribbler** (69 DRI) — and one of the lowest defences (62). They drew twice and lost once.
- **Gary Edwards FC had no recognised GK** (Chris Hughes was a last-minute add) — purely lucky they didn't get punished.

What actually happened that night

Aaron FC 0 - 0 Gary FC · cagey

Aaron FC 1 - 0 Josh FC

Aaron FC 2 - 1 Mikel FC · Aaron 9 pts · **WINNERS**

Gary FC 0 - 0 Josh FC

Gary FC 2 - 0 Mikel FC

Mikel FC 2 - 1 Josh FC · 4 of 6 games had margin ≤ 1 , but two stomps included

► What v2 would have done

The new algorithm balances on **every** category, not just overall. Constraints layered on top:

- **Categorical balance**: each attribute total within ± 4 across teams.
- **GK guarantee**: each team gets ≥ 1 recognised GK.
- **Defender floor**: each team gets ≥ 1 player with DEF ≥ 8 .
- **Star cap**: max 2 players with OVR ≥ 8 per team.
- **Simulated annealing**: random swap pairs of equal-OVR players to drive imbalance down. ~1000 iterations, <100ms.

The simulated-annealing output (3 swaps from actual)

Same 36 players. Three swaps: Tom Broughton ↔ Stan Finch · Felix Baker ↔ Mark Pearson · Adam Thorpe ↔ Joseph Pender.

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Aaron Franklin FC	64	62	65	64	67	69
Gary Edwards FC	63	60	65	65	67	69
Josh Edwards FC	67	61	67	66	66	66
Mikel Winter FC	66	59	67	64	68	69
Spread	±4	±3	±2	±2	±2	±3

Impact: SHO spread went from ±12 → ±3. DRI from ±8 → ±2. PHY from ±9 → ±3. Three swaps, no team identity broken. Aaron FC keeps Beau Samuels as their star; the swaps happened among the support players.

Why it matters over the season

- **Closer games** — fewer 6-0 stomps means more fun for everyone.
- **Fairer "Winning Team" stat** — wins will reflect player quality more than draft luck.
- **Trustable "Wall" stat** — GA per night becomes a real defensive signal once defences aren't lopsided.
- **Validation:** after 4 weeks of v2, expect avg score differential to drop from ~2.5 → ~1.5 goals.

Admin escape hatch — admin can still drag-swap players post-balance. The algorithm is a suggestion, not a mandate. Add a "regenerate" button to try a fresh allocation if a particular output looks off.

RATE YOUR SQUAD

PEER RATING · LOW-FRICTION DESIGN

P702 · PROPOSAL

The problem — MOTM/DOTD engagement is low because it feels altruistic and takes too many clicks. Peer ratings could be gold for the balancer, but only if 60%+ of the squad actually does them every week. [This proposal designs around the engagement gap, not the data we want.](#)

► Design principles

- **≤ 20 seconds** total — finished before you've cracked your second beer.
- **One screen, no scrolling** — the whole squad visible at once.
- **One tap per teammate** — three colours, no text input, no comments.
- **Selfish incentive** — gate [your](#) rating behind doing the work.
- **Combined with MOTM/DOTD** — same screen, not three separate flows.

► The flow

P201 · POST MATCH

RATE YOUR SQUAD

Aaron Franklin FC · 8 teammates · 9 PM K.O.

Your form rating: locked

Rate your teammates to unlock yours · 5 of 8 done

BS Beau Samuels



AF Aaron F



GA Geof A



CD Corin D



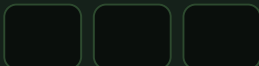
PM Peter M



EE Edward E



SD Scott D



OC Ollie C



► The behaviour loop

Trigger

Push notification fires **10pm Thursday** (after the match): "How was the squad? 20 seconds and your form rating updates." Single tap deep-links straight to this screen. No menu navigation required.

Selfish hook

Player's own form rating (a single 1–5 number on their card) is hidden behind a lock icon until they've rated [their own teammates](#). Same psychology as "see who liked you" on Hinge — give to get.

Streak

Top of the screen: "4 weeks in a row · keep the streak". Breaking a streak feels worse than starting one. Players will tap through just to keep the flame alive.

Anonymity

Players see [their](#) aggregated form (e.g. "Your squad rated you 4.2"), but never [who](#) rated what. Removes social cost and frees honest ratings.

MOTM & DOTD baked in

After the 7 colour taps, the final screen shows the players you tagged and asks "[Pick MOTM](#)". One tap. Same for → DOTD. Total: ~9 taps. No more separate flow.

3 more to unlock · then pick MOTM & DOTD

Forgetters

If you forget, the screen still works any time before Friday 9am. After: locked, your form rating doesn't update for that week (small penalty — incentive without punishment).

► What the data unlocks

- **Form rating** — fold the rolling 4-match peer score into the card's **overall** with ± 3 weight. Cards feel "alive".
- **Balancer signal** — a player on a hot peer-rated streak gets a small synthetic boost; one on a cold streak gets cooled. Stops "the lazy week" from being silently rewarded by the balancer.
- **MOTM & DOTD higher quality** — comes from people who actually watched the match (the squad), not casual viewers.
- **Engagement metric** — track "% of squad who rated" each week. Initial target: 60%. Aim 75% by month 3.

► Why people will actually do it

MOTIVATION	MECHANIC
Curiosity about own rating	Gate · "5 of 8 done"
Loss aversion	Streak counter
Tribal pride	"Aaron FC has a 4.1 squad rating · 2nd in league"
Banter	Friday morning recap card · "Edward Ezra was on form (4.6)"
Influence	Your rating literally moves the balancer next week

Combined effect · v2 balancer + peer ratings = teams that are mathematically fairer
· and ratings that match how players actually played.